

FIELD AND STREAM

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THE PUMA IN THE FOG

A Story of the Venezuelan Mountains

By KONRAD A. BRANDT

PEDRO and Calixto, my *peones*, went away to the next *bodega* to discuss the start and to refresh themselves with *agua panela* (fermenting sugar water), which is the favorite beverage of Venezuela's lower classes. I walked slowly across the plaza, in which jostled a goodly crowd of men and women. There were also children, of course, but as even two-year-old babes are most solemnly addressed as "*Señor*" or "*Señora*" I don't know whether they are regarded as children or adults. Most of these were farmers, who stayed in town over night to seek recreation from the day's hard labor; for it had been market day. They were awaiting impatiently the beginning of the concert by the municipal band, which usually played every other night on one of the plazas. Very few couples were to be seen; the sexes kept well apart—perhaps it was not yet dark enough to carry on flirtations. Almost everybody smoked, the men, male children included, openly; the women concealed their *cigarillos* in the hollow of their hands and enjoyed them perhaps the more on this account. For 2 reales (the rate for natives is $\frac{1}{2}$ real; all foreigners have to pay more) I hired a chair. It was a clumsy, rawhide-covered affair, of ancient Spanish pattern and surpassed in comfort only by a Morris

chair. I lighted one of the rank native cigars, which are nearly as bad as Trust cigars, and looked up to the sky. It is impossible to describe the brilliancy of the tropical star-covered sky, just as nobody can imagine, nor those who have seen it describe, the intense, magic blue of the West Indian sea. The so-called Southern Cross was visible, too, and once more I wondered how such a misshapen thing, not even particularly prominent, could ever induce poetic effusion. I always thought it most appropriately the celestial counterpart of the cross with which all South America is burdened—politics, which are also badly out of joint. Big white clouds were creeping slowly over the mountains, and, like immense avalanches, rolled down the slopes and filled the valleys and gaps. Silvery they shone in the light of the rising moon. The Queen of the Night glows with such brightness in the tropics that small print can be read without difficulty. No longer was it night; nor was it day. High above the distant clouds, far over the gloom of the nearby world, rose an ice-clad peak, one of the few in South America which are covered with eternal snow and ice. Two days before I had the good fortune to see the *Andenglühen*, which is not so spectacular as the *Alpenglühen*, but very impressive nevertheless.

SEA OTTER SHOOTING

A California Coast Sport That is Full of Excitement and Silence

By FRANK GASSAWAY

BEGINNING due west of Point Conception on the California coast, and continuing at irregular intervals as far south as the Bay of Todos Santos in Lower California, lie the Channel Islands. These vary in length from a few miles to over thirty, and keep an average distance from the mainland of about twenty-five miles. Only one of this chain has any special claim to being inhabited—Santa Catalina, the sea-side resort now world famous as the only place where the leaping tuna—well named the “Tiger of the Sea”—can be taken. With the exception of an occasional lonely shepherd’s hut on one or two of the larger islands, the rest of these outlying barriers to the trade-wind-driven surges of the Pacific remain as they were at creation’s dawn, and even to-day are given up solely to the sea-lions that doze and bellow upon their reefs, and that no less civilization-avoiding creature, the otter hunter.

Every kind of marine animal and fish, from the whale to the translucent porpoise; from the 500-pound, boat-dragging Jew-fish to the no less game bonita, albacore, and barracouda, swarm unmolested in the unvexed depths to the lee of these islands. And should the seafaring sportsman voyaging along the succession of peaceful coves wish for game he has only to cast anchor to find food for powder at the very beach’s edge. Coyotes and red foxes slink through the underbrush, a rabbit starts from every bush, and endless coveys of quail scarce elude his steps. In this ideal region for the yachtsman, the fisherman, and the hunter, one comes to feel like a new Crusoe on his primitive isle. And in very truth Crusoe’s semi-mythical story was enacted upon one of these same islands, though minus the man Friday and the happy ending. The castaway in this case was a woman, a Danish emigrant, left ashore through some mischance by the crew of a vessel

that had sought shelter behind San Nicholas during a storm, in the early fifties. For over seventeen years the lone creature lived unsought and forgotten, though the time at length came, when, on the days the mist-clearing north wind blew, she could climb to the island’s highest point and view the ranchers’ herds grazing upon the mainland. And at last, when hope and reason had both long died, the poor, wild, gibbering creature was found in her wolf’s burrow among the hills by the advance guard of the otter hunters’ fraternity, who had long wondered at the mysterious footprints they marked upon the lonely sands. But it is of these otter hunters and their prey with which we have to do just now.

During a recent winter vacation spent at Santa Barbara the writer heard so many widely differing, and, for the most part, imaginative, accounts of the fur-hunting denizens of the Channel Islands, their hermit-like inaccessibility, and their semi-savage repulsion of strangers, that he determined upon a voyage of discovery and whatever sport and adventure might be its accompaniment. A small fishing sloop was engaged, and, with some trouble, made less reminiscent of its calling, and more yacht-like. With a crew consisting of the skipper, his brother, and the inevitable “boy,” all Portuguese, we stood out from the harbor one morning, and at sundown came to anchor in a lovely little placid and surflless cove at the northern end of San Nicholas.

To relate the fishing within the circle of a line’s cast from the sloop, or the shooting within a stone’s throw of the beach, that the writer enjoyed for the ensuing four days, would be another story, and perhaps fascinating to yacht cruisers everywhere, for the scene was as virgin to the nimrod’s art as it was in the days of Balboa.

We moved lazily south, each anchorage the same silver-beached repetition of the others, and ever keeping a wary lookout for some signs of the habitations of the otter hunters, with some of whom our skipper claimed an acquaintance, made during their brief and infrequent visits to the mainland. At length a shadowy spiral of smoke, issuing from behind a pile of huge rocks on the shore, rewarded our vigilance, and the small tender transferred us to the beach, where we were almost startled by the apparition of a half-dozen silent and motionless figures regarding us from the shadows of the bushes. Two of these came slowly forward, and were respectfully accosted by our skipper as "Pedro" and "Juanie," the Mexican equivalents of Peter and John. One, we later learned, was a Forty-niner, originally from Kentucky, while the other was a long-acclimated downeaster who had done good service as a sharpshooter during the Geronimo outbreak. The others were Mexicans.

"Can you find room for a traveler for a few days?"

"What fur?" asked Pedro, in a slow and modulated tone.

"I would like to learn something about otter hunting, if you don't object."

"What fur?" again murmured Pedro, after a long meditative silence devoted to puffing one of the very excellent cigars the writer had made diplomatic haste to pass around.

"I would like to write something about them."

"Fur a noospaper? Over there?" with a jerk of the head toward the mainland. He shook his head negatively, as did his companion in silent protest.

"Not at all. For the East—three thousand miles away," said the writer. "Not even that, if you object."

"Well, if 'tain't fur 't'her side, I reckon it's all right," and, motioning the others to carry the luggage, Pedro led the way toward the camp.

This proved to be a few stone-built and clay-plastered huts placed behind a huge boulder, and almost as little calculated to attract the passer's attention as the cunningly hidden "keeps" of the otters themselves. The larger of these was the

assembly-room and kitchen, furnished chiefly with cumbersome home-made chairs and a long table. A few smoke-faded pictures and rudely stuffed rare water birds adorned the walls. In a recess near the ample fireplace stood that holiest of holies, the gun rack, loaded with carefully oiled rifles, while in the corner reposed a couple of less-esteemed shot-guns of antiquated make. A well-thumbed book or two, and, oddly enough, an out-of-date edition of Shakespeare, were the only literary resources.

"You kin say in your noospaper," softly drawled the Kentuckian, with an inspiration of commercial sagacity evidently approved by his colleagues, "that there's mighty few on 'em left, and if many more 'vyergers come visitin' round these ilins it's good-bye, Mary Jane! You can't crowd 'em. Why, I kin remember when even in the fifties you could git otter anywheres along the main coast. I dessey 'Frisco bay was oncet full on 'em, but they lit out. An' what did it? Someuns allow the steamboats and sich, but I says the humming v'ice. They jest can't stan' the humming v'ice. An' now where are they? Nary a one anywhere 'cept here and 'way up in Alaska, where they shoots 'em, I've hearn, from atop of perches stuck up in the surf. In the surf, mind yer!" and the expert glanced around in indignant reprobation at this upstart sportsmanlike practice. "Yes, sir; it's the humming v'ice as is thinin' 'em off. Why, a picnic came over here 'bout five years ago from Santa B., an' we fell off that season 'bout two hundred skins. Fact." And his companions nodded a sympathetic approval.

The small community that subsist by this occupation numbers perhaps some 200 souls in all, and is indeed a most peculiar and isolated one. For over a generation they have retained a monopoly of their pursuit, and resent all professional competition with jealous hostility. Living apart from the haunts of mankind, touching elbows with civilization only at rare intervals, and rendered silent and undemonstrative by the very nature of their profession, they live on, care free, contented and unregardful of the great world "on the main." Their

stations, or "camps," similar to this, are usually about eight or ten miles apart. The inmates or "crews" are about ninety per cent. native Californians, the rest Americans, and are divided in three distinct classes. The least important of these are the "grubbers," or fishermen, skin-salters, and cooks, who find and prepare the food. Next come the boatmen, whose sole occupation is rowing, and lastly, the "shots," or riflemen, almost always American, and who are the magnates and aristocrats of the outfit, it being upon their skill the welfare of the whole depends. The latter specialists, like Peter and John, fully appreciate their importance and dignity, and exact a consideration and respect from their less distinguished partners edifying to observe. Although the business is largely a co-operative one the riflemen are paid an additional ten per cent. of the "catch" and also obtain a further bonus of one dollar and fifty cents per skin for each pelt above a certain number secured each month. No trade unionist could be more jealous of the intrusion of apprentices than are these experts, and a rifleman would consider it a loss of caste to touch an oar or even lend a hand at the launching of a boat.

The shooting is all done from boats, four or five of which are always beached in front of each camp. These are home-made affairs, low on the sides, nearly flat-bottomed for convenience in beaching and sliding over kelp, and are intended for two oarsmen, a steersman and rifleman. Their internal arrangements are somewhat unique, the double object of facilitating the marksmen and insuring complete silence being kept always in view. In the bow, where the sharpshooter sits in lordly state, is placed the only modern article, if his latest pattern rifle be excepted, observable. This is the upper half of an office chair, revolving on a well-oiled screw to afford its occupant a quick change of position. Under the generally bare feet of the crew are spread old blankets. The wooden oar-locks are covered with generously greased felt, the oars themselves oval-bladed, thin-shafted and flexible, while on either side of the sharp bow trail strips of loose skin, fur

side out, against which the splash of the water is inaudible. Everything, in fact, is done to avoid the slightest sound while afloat, for the sea otter, as has been indicated, seems to rely more upon his acuteness of hearing than his sense of smell or sight.

Long before all this information was elicited from the two captains; or "shots," the rest of the hands had retired into the adjoining hut devoted to sleeping bunks, in the widest and most comfortable of which the writer passed a restful night in anticipation of an early start in the morning.

In the dim grayness of the early hour at which all wild creatures seem to break their fast, five silent, ghostlike figures, comprising Pedro, two oarsmen, the steersman and the writer, took their way to the water's edge and quietly launched a boat fitted and provisioned over night. Not a word was spoken, not an oar rattled, for even then a venturesome otter might be a few hundred yards away. The writer was stationed on a covered box in front of the steersman with a whispered injunction from that official to "chin easy." The crew melted into their places as would buccancers on a cutting-out expedition; the "shot" lifted his hand; the lithe blades stole through the water without a drip, and the boat glided seaward like a shadow.

About 300 yards from the shore we saw that the kelp line followed the curves of the land like a sleeping serpent, the leaves of its forty-foot-long stems matting together on the surface in a reddish-brown mass about 500 feet in width. The clothing of the hunters, the boat itself, were of the same tint. This undulating forest of stems and leaves harbors a marine world of its own. A fascinating volume could be filled with the strange fishes, the separate organisms, peculiar to its depths, and seen nowhere else. It is here the otter repairs from his rocky lair and, supported by the giant stems, lies in wait for his prey.

Our boat was carefully steered about thirty yards from the inner kelp line, and the rifleman, his wide sombrero brim folded in so as to exclude the light except in front, glued his eye to the oily surface

to seaward. Sometimes he grasped his cocked rifle tighter as some pursued flying-fish broke above the still swell, or some bit of kelp lifted itself higher than the rest. Suddenly his trained eye caught a sharp lift of the water head. It was the "fluke" made by the quick upward stroke of the startled otter's hind feet and tail as he forced himself under water in his frantic race for the shore.

Now if the otter would only content himself with remaining in the kelp, amid whose patches of leaves his recurrent nose would remain undetected, all would be well, but his invariable habit is to make a bee-line for headquarters. Long experience has taught the marksman that in doing this his quarry must make exactly three dives; that is to say, he must come to the surface to breathe just twice in his course. The first of these "breaks" would be almost exactly in front of the boat, and with rifle butt at shoulder, but with his head held high and both eyes wide open—for this quickest of snap-shooting allows no time for sighting—Pedro watched almost the exact spot at which the sleek, pointer-like head would in a moment appear.

"Crack!" For an instant—about the space required to count rapidly "one two, three"—the brown spot appeared and vanished, before the rifle-smoke had floated an inch from the muzzle.

Another quick fluke ahead, and then a slow smoothing of the ripples.

"A clean miss!"

The fact was signaled to the crew by the quick ejection of the empty shell, which was the signal for the landward oars to hold water while the steersman headed sharply toward the shore. The boat stopped as nearly as possible over the locality of the first "break," for by this means the next shot, though at a distance of from seventy to ninety yards, would have the advantage of being a "line" one. With set face and partly-raised rifle Pedro leaned forward, every muscle and nerve at highest tension, and, catlike, watched a certain spot halfway between the boat and a clump of rocks on the shore. Long practice had already informed him of the condition of the animal, indicated by the

distance covered by his first dive, and he could almost spread a blanket over the fugitive's next breathing place.

"Crack!" again; and this time a fatal flurry in the water proclaimed success.

Now everything depended upon the spurting capacities of the rowers, and the boat fairly flew through the water in the direction of the kill. Just in time! Leaning over the bow Pedro seized the feebly fighting prize and deftly twisted it into the boat. Next to killing, it is most important to retrieve the game at once, for the otter sinks immediately when dead. True, in from five to eight days, even sooner in east windy weather, the animal would be washed ashore, but in such cases its fur is usually found to be abraded by the rocks, or mutilated by crabs.

Again our course was south, keeping the same prescribed distance from the kelp's margin. A half mile slipped by and once more the indomitable scrutiny of Pedro was rewarded. This time it was a close-at-hand kill with the first shot; but a few inches' miscalculation by the steersman almost lost us the otter. Pedro missed his plunge, but the sinking quarry's tail was seized by the writer just in the nick of time as the boat rushed by, an achievement that raised him very measurably in the estimation of the voicelessly applauding crew.

Then followed, within a distance of a mile and a half, four more trophies of Pedro's skill, two to the first, and as many to the second shot, only one entire failure at the longer distance. When this last occurred nothing more was done, and the lucky animal was permitted to escape until another opportunity. But, successful or otherwise, not a word or sound was heard, and our dumb boat silently wheeled and sped along on its stealthy quest.

Ten miles and 10 o'clock. The sun was beginning to warm to its work; the otters had left their foraging grounds and the boat was turned to the shore. Here a well-earned siesta was enjoyed during the long wait until the second or "supper" shooting time arrived. This was broken at noon by a lunch none the less hearty that it was eaten in a silence that might

be envied by a brotherhood of speech-abjuring monks.

At 6 o'clock the return trip was begun and resulted in two more additions to the handsome store of pelts occupying the box behind the rifleman's seat. Eleven in all, being, as the spectral steersman, José, relaxed himself so far as to whisper as we approached the camp, "six singles, five doubles and a *carambo*"; the two first expressions indicating the number of cartridges used by the shooter, and the last expletive to accompany a miss.

The fact was subsequently developed, and is interesting as indicating the unconscious education of the muscles and sight, that while the otter expert shoots with marvelous precision at the two distances described, they are almost ineffectual at greater ranges. It is to be doubted if they would make any showing at from 250 to 500 yards, a description by the writer of a long-range match and its scores being received by the campers

with a good deal of amused incredulity, an evident instance of the prevaricating tendencies of the benighted inhabitants of the despised main land to the east.

The day's work had been an exceptional one; the bag was a truly royal one in a financial sense, for its value was just eleven times forty-two dollars, the present market price of the "green" skins in bulk; for the sea otter, like the buffalo, is passing away, and already his coat has become the vestment for only the very wealthy.

As the night's shadows deepened out from the hushed hills our boat grated upon the home beach, and the tired crew stepped again over the side. And thus from day to day the tireless quest goes on, and for the same end, if my simple hosts but knew it, that inspires the busy toilers on the dim shores that lie to the east. But who shall say that the peaceful dwellers in these sylvan solitudes have not the happier lot?

THE MISSISSAGA RIVER TRIP

The Delights of a Canoe Cruise of Over Two Hundred Miles Through a Virgin Wilderness in Northern Ontario

By G. M. RICHARDS

SOME two hundred miles north of Lake Huron, near where the Woman river on its way to Moose Factory tunnels the railroad, stands a little one-room cabin. Except by an occasional forest prowler, it has long been deserted; the nearest human habitation is thirty miles away. Someone with a grim sense of humor called it Winnebago, from the Ojibway name of the stream which flows almost past the door, and so it appears on the map to-day. It has but one excuse for its existence—it is the "jumping-off place" for the Mississaga river trip.

It was there that we met our guides as we climbed reluctantly from the sleeper one frosty morning in September, and

there we had our first breakfast of bacon, flapjacks and coffee, with the earth as our table and all out-of-doors as our dining-room.

Before starting on the cruise we followed an old Indian trail to the summit of a little hill that rises abruptly from the almost level country. As far as the eye could reach stretched a waving green sea of treetops broken only here and there by a diminutive lake or an occasional beaver meadow. Below us, winding away into the unknown north like a tiny silver thread, rushed the Winnebago on its way to join the mighty Moose.

Just as the morning sun struggled up through the dense jungle of spruce and cedar along shore, we dipped our paddles